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RESEARCH ARTICLE

‘Time for School’? School fees, savings clubs and social reciprocity in Uganda

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The past 25 years have witnessed sweeping educational reforms in Uganda. The introduction of ‘free’ Universal Primary Education (UPE, in 1998) and Universal Secondary Education (USE, in 2007) has raised social expectations about access to quality education. Over the same period the population of young people in Uganda has also grown dramatically. As a result hundreds of new primary and secondary schools have been established across the country. This article examines the social and economic consequences for a rural part of Southwest Uganda. Bringing together secondary data from national household surveys with detailed ethnographic research, the article highlights families’ material and social investments in schooling. It explores the costs faced by even the poorest households whose children attend ‘free’ government schools. Despite public investment, the poor quality of state provision has led to public frustration and demands for reforms. Survey data demonstrate that, as a result, wealthier households are investing in education, sending their children to private schools to benefit from smaller class sizes and better learning outcomes. The article describes how people use a range of social arrangements, including rotating savings and credit associations to manage school fees and access credit in this part of Uganda. Drawing on recent work by Graeber and others, we argue that people are creating new social relationships within these savings clubs. Whilst managing their financial commitments, people invoke and rework existing idioms of reciprocity, interdependence and patronage. The use of human capital theory to explain schooling choices in relation to individual economic or social ‘returns’ downplays the sociality of these arrangements. We argue that educational commitments are now an integral part of the Ugandan social landscape, generating aspiration, nurturing networks and creating new inequalities.

Keywords: universal primary education; private schooling; savings clubs; reciprocity

On coming to power in January 1986, President Yoweri Museveni’s ruling National Resistance Movement (NRM) prioritized education reform. The influential Education Policy Review Commission (EPRC) of 1987 set out a blueprint to rebuild a sector damaged by years of political unrest in the country.¹ As well as rehabilitating schools, the Commission redesigned the primary school curriculum, established a new system of national standards and oversaw a major expansion in teacher training provision.

The most radical element of the EPRC’s report was its suggestion that Uganda implement Universal Primary Education (UPE). The idea became central both to

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Museveni's successful 1996 presidential election campaign and to the policy agendas of the major development agencies, including Britain's Department for International Development.² Shortly after his 1996 re-election, Museveni began to implement the UPE programme, initially with a view to providing 'free' education for up to four children per household nationwide.³ In line with these policy shifts and meeting the needs of a rapidly growing population, levels of government spending on education rose from 21% (1995) to peak at 35% (1999) of total Government expenditure, as did donor support and private sector investment across all parts of the formal education sector.

Initially, UPE was judged a success. Within just a few months of its introduction in 1997, primary enrolments had jumped from 3.1 million to 5.3 million.⁴ Yet despite World Bank data that net enrolment of primary schoolchildren had reached 91% by 2011, Uganda's own household panel survey data suggest that average enrolment is closer to 82% (much lower in the North) and has actually been falling since 2002.⁵ Primary school completion rates remain around 50% and recent evidence about children's literacy and numeracy is also far from impressive.⁶ The UPE policy remains popular, as indicated by overcrowded classrooms and teachers working 'double-shifts', but it has highlighted the challenge of ensuring high quality provision and learning outcomes.⁷

Beyond this national picture of frustrated aspirations, we know relatively little about the way this new educational landscape has become part of social and economic life in the country. Much of the research on Uganda's UPE experiment has focused on the policy and implementation processes, not on how educational 'choices' and investments become integral aspects of everyday life. The present article extends our knowledge of this social world of education through secondary data analysis and detailed ethnographic study of one rural community in Southwest Uganda. We explore why education continues to be a priority for many Ugandans, how households are managing the financial burdens posed by 'school fees' and other schooling-related costs, and how these demands need to be understood as part of a collective capacity to aspire and seek educational alternatives. Whilst Sen argues for the fundamental 'human capabilities' developed through these new forms of reciprocity and peer-support, we highlight a rather more complex relationship between autonomy, personhood and morality.⁸

Why invest in education?

Census statistics and household surveys highlight the challenges facing educational reform in Uganda. The 2014 census⁹ shows that Uganda's population is growing at over 3% each year, and 34.9 million represents a 76% increase on Uganda's 1997 population of 22.1 million, the year UPE was introduced. In 2013, Uganda had one of the highest total fertility rates in the world (6.2), partly driven by President Museveni's pronatalist policies. This has led to a particularly youthful age structure, and in 2013 children of school-going age (5–18) made up 40% of the population. The expansion in educational provision over the last 15 years has had to cope with providing for an extra five million children of school-going age, equivalent to 5000 new schools of 1000 students each.

Initially, academic and policy research tended to emphasize the benefits wrought by UPE. The policy prioritized gender equity, by requiring, where possible, two of the four children funded per household via UPE to be girls, and insisted on access for children with disabilities.¹⁰ To begin with, primary school completion rates improved, especially among girls, if accompanied by a drop in educational attainment at P5 level.¹¹ UPE was perceived to have been so successful at improving both enrolment and completion rates, that in 2007, Universal Secondary Education (USE) was introduced as well, though this

has proved more costly and difficult to implement.¹² Meanwhile, for wealthier families, the growth of the private education sector expanded the range of choices available for their children's education, a development that has been encouraged by some donors, and in 2014, 750 such schools were registered and funded under a public–private partnership agreement.

More recently research and journalistic evidence has painted a far less rosy picture of these changes. A series of media articles have highlighted growing drop-out rates and overcrowded classrooms in what have become known as 'USE schools'. One recent media account described a Kampala school with 3100 children enrolled and classes of 80 students to one teacher.¹³ Private schools (which receive a government capitation fee to cover USE) have been accused of creating 'ghost students', leading President Museveni to withdraw capitation funding from private schools in 2014.¹⁴

Enrolment rates at state schools are also inflated by heads and district officials, and primary school completion rates remain stagnant at around 54% nationally. This signals a high level of school drop-outs and highlights the different factors that influence decisions facing families who seek to educate their children. The Uganda 2012/2013 household survey recorded primary school class sizes averaging 49 in private schools and 76 in government schools and noted that respondents cited cost as a key reason for their children's lack of attendance. More than 50% of female students cited marriage or pregnancy as their reason for leaving school. A 2013 World Bank report noted that only 40% of primary school classrooms had a teacher present at the point of survey, highlighting the challenge of teacher absenteeism because of delays in salary payments and poor school leadership.¹⁵

In this context it is not surprising that the comprehensive annual education assessment reports by UWEZO paint a depressing picture, with only one P3 child in every 10 having the most basic skills in numeracy and literacy, and 20% of children not having these skills in P7. The report also highlighted stark differences between regions and between private and public schools. It also highlights the importance of focusing on learning outcomes rather than educational inputs.

To what extent are these challenges and limitations reflected in household decisions around education? Uganda National Household Survey (UNHS) data offer insight into household financial commitments over time in different parts of Uganda and, in particular, the range of educational costs. Findings from the 2012/2013 UNHS¹⁶ show that almost one in five Ugandans took out a loan to cover the costs of education, up from 17% in 2005, despite the introduction of USE. One in three Ugandans in the Southwest made use of such loans (including the informal credit arrangements that savings clubs provide), double the national average.

Household panel data in 2012/2013 from a sample of 100 families in Mbarara that recorded their monthly costs are especially revealing. The total monthly spend on education varied from less than \$2 to more than \$1200, showing the range of incomes. The great majority of these costs went on school fees. The distribution is heavily skewed by around 20 households with a total expenditure of more than \$300/month. When the richest 20% (and the poorest 10%) of households are not included, the average household expenditure was around \$60.

Whilst nationally the share of monthly household spending on education went down between 2009 and 2012 (from 9.6% to 7.2% nationally), partly in light of the increasing costs of food, it remains a significant expenditure for many households, and one that is the most 'elastic' of all household expenditures. Rich households spend proportionately more on education, and spending increases proportionally with income. Whilst the

poorest households will pay very little, the costs of school uniforms and stationery are not insignificant. Nationally average spending on education was around \$48/month in 2012, significantly more than the \$31 spent on food, a figure skewed by the high costs of the most expensive private schools (up to \$1000 a month in some cases). Madhavan-Nambiar et al. suggest that this points to the 'relatively higher benefits from increasing income and school access outside the capital'.¹⁷ Spending in rural areas as a proportion of total household income is also higher than in urban areas. As they note however, the relationship of educational expenditure to other items of expenditure is key.

Whilst this sort of quantitative data is valuable, it can encourage an analytical focus on households as sites of rational cost benefit analysis and decision-making. It also acts as a vehicle for economistic thinking. Theorizing about peoples' decisions to invest in human 'capital' in this way was popularized by the World Bank in the 1980s, but it has increasingly come under criticism for its atomistic and mechanistic separation of interwoven social and economic factors. As Fine and Rose (2001: 160) note, the more factors that are 'introduced to refine estimates of educational functions ... the more education is seen to be part and parcel of society and societal functioning as a whole, and not appropriately reducible to a function specifying educational outputs and inputs'.¹⁸ It may well be that families are withdrawing children from school because they can be used to make more valuable contributions to the household through agricultural and domestic labour. But these decisions will also be made in the light of a whole range of factors that cannot all be modelled, such as: the quality of school provision, a student's academic progress, family size, sickness, teenage pregnancy, labour availability, etc.

Attempts by human capital theorists to model long-term educational benefits in terms of additional wages or returns to employment end up isolating education as a measurable variable. Following Sen's focus on social justice, we would argue that a more holistic emphasis on education as developing human capability and a collective social good more insightfully explains Ugandans' educational aspirations and the efforts of many families to support their children's ambitions. Dreze and Sen argue that the benefits from long-term social investment in universal health and education made by some Indian states in the 1960s and 1970s were made possible through democratic politics.¹⁹ Sen's moral vision is of development as the freedom for a person to actually do the 'things that he or she may value doing or being' (2009: 232). His interpretation of this as 'the various combinations of functionings (beings and doings) that the person can achieve' (Sen 1992: x) captures his emphasis on the moral ability of individuals to evaluate and make choices about education. Whilst we support his holistic reframing of development debates, we question any neat association of financial with moral 'autonomy' and draw on Graeber's theorisation of reciprocity to understand the complex social dynamics and responsibilities created through these new financial exchanges.

USE and UPE were political vote-winners, and the challenges Uganda faces in implementing high-quality educational provision have not diminished education as a source of hope and aspiration. The long-term social and economic benefits of education may be constrained by the continuing dominance of subsistence farming as a main source of household income for more than 70% of Ugandans. But these benefits are also being limited by poor quality provision, limited teacher training and morale, high levels of childhood morbidity and mortality, the lack of a national family planning policy, infrastructure, transport and access to loans, to name but a few. In this context, it is important to look beyond the household to understand the broader social dynamics and expectations that surround educational aspirations and investments.

UPE and the rising cost of 'School fees'

Despite the continuing popular appeal of 'free' primary education for Ugandans, it has never been anywhere near free. When UPE was first introduced in 1997, the programme was structured around two major funding streams, both of which were paid from central government to the district administrations, and from there passed on to the schools themselves. The first of these streams took the form of a capitation grant, calculated on a per pupil basis (the grant was initially set at approximately \$3 per pupil per month for P1–P3, and around \$5 per month for P4–P7 – although these figures have since risen slightly), the second a 'school facilities grant', which was designed to cover the costs of facilities maintenance, the purchase of new textbooks and other resources, and so on. However, from the very beginning, these combined funding streams failed to meet almost all schools' actual funding requirements. All UPE funding had to pass through district administrations, introducing a range of inefficiencies, and a degree of wastage. A series of public expenditure tracking studies have shown that some districts were taking as long as three months to pass on their UPE funds to schools, whilst others were losing as much as 10% of the money along the way (through either inefficiency or corruption). On the other hand, both UPE funding streams were designed to cover schools' *recurrent* costs only, and not capital expenditure costs (new buildings, furniture, etc.) or the requirement to meet occasional one-off financial 'shocks'. In addition, the capitation grant stream was never adjusted to account for the rising costs of teachers' salaries. These jumped during the late 1990s, due to a general shortage of trained teachers across the public sector, both because of the rising number of pupils attending government schools, and an increasing number of teachers moving to work in a growing, and much more lucrative, private sector. Indeed, as a result of all of these factors, one early study found that shortly after the introduction of 'free' education, combined UPE funds were, on average, meeting only about 15% of schools' 'total student-year costs'.

As a result, and partly because of the introduction of UPE and USE, schools were forced to continue raising additional funds via parent subsidies. Most continued to rely on Parent–Teacher Association (PTA) contributions. Although PTAs were technically abolished under UPE, in practice they proved almost impossible to disband, given how integral they had become to Uganda's educational funding. In many parts of the country, PTAs had effectively taken over the running of schools during the troubled years of the 1970s and early 1980s, and had thus even become a source of great pride, and an important motivator for teachers, given the way they supplemented government salaries. In consequence, both the schools themselves and their parents saw them as the 'natural' vehicle to use for raising additional funds. By 1992, the average cost of a PTA contribution in a rural public primary school had risen to approx. \$8 per child per year, in an urban school to around \$80. Some districts did take measures to disband them, but this did not stop the schools involved from still charging their parents. In these contexts, the schools simply came up with other (and indeed, ever more creative) mechanisms for doing so. Thus, rather than PTA contributions, public schools now raise additional funds through 'building fund' contributions, extra (out of hours) tuition fees, 'summer school' enrolments, 'one-off' fundraisers, extra-curricular activities (especially sports and excursions) charges, and so on. Both local and national authorities try to enforce this legislation. In 2011, the Uganda Police carried out a series of raids at schools in Mbarara Town, in an attempt to end the practice of charging for 'Saturday classes'. Some schools also require students to make donations in kind (such as cleaning materials, paper for printing, produce for lunch) to cover what is called school 'up-keep'. A national teachers'

strike early in 2013 made the explicit restoration of PTA contributions a key demand, as well as wage increases and the prompt payment of salaries.²⁰

As a result of all this, the cost of 'school fees' – the English phrase is used by most Ugandans to refer to all types of payments – has increased for almost all households following the advent of UPE. These 'top-ups' account for only one portion of household investment in their children's education. In addition to the various types of top-ups, a household with an increasing number of children attending school will also have to meet rising uniform and stationary costs. By 1998, uniform costs alone accounted for almost 25% of households' out-of-pocket education-related expenses, across both rural and urban areas.²¹ If children complete primary school, the costs of attending secondary school and even university present additional financial demands.

It is not only households reliant on public primary schools that have seen costs rise in these ways. Since the mid-1990s, wealthier households educating their children in a burgeoning private sector have also experienced steadily rising fees and other school-related costs. Private schools vary greatly in quality and charges, but even the least well-resourced will tend to have a higher standard than the closest government school. As a result, families will often seek to transfer children to these schools if they can afford the additional fees.

In this context, then, anxiety over 'school fees' has become commonplace; a discourse in which practically everyone, regardless of their locality, class or social background, now engages. As one of our respondents – a resident of a small rural town – put it, 'there is not a single person in this place, if not the whole of Uganda, who is not lying awake worrying about school fees right now'. These are more than just private concerns. Discussion about the quality of education pervades Uganda's public culture. In his successive election victories, Museveni has continued to make access to education a key policy priority, such as the implementation in 2013 of a nationwide student-loan scheme, to help households to meet the costs of tertiary education.²²

School fees and the growth of Rotating Savings and Credit Associations

Despite limited evidence that measures individual financial 'returns' on education, many families continue to make major emotional, social and economic commitments to education. In this section, we draw on ethnographic work to show how residents of one rural sub-county in south-west Uganda have responded to increasing household financial burdens by increasing their participation in, and involvement with savings clubs and credit associations.²³ These associations, which the residents of Bugamba themselves commonly refer to by the Runyankore/Rukiga term *ekigombe* (plural: *ebigombe*) are described in the development and academic literature as Rotating Savings and Credit Associations (RoSCAs) or alternatively as 'circulating credit groups', or 'money-go rounds', or 'wagon-wheels'.²⁴ Shipton highlights the growth of these microfinance initiatives across Africa in the late 1980s, a by-product of the IMF's structural adjustment policies and the growing fashion for loans rather than project grants.

RoSCAs are essentially savings clubs, whereby all members pay in a fixed amount at regular intervals, and then take it in turns to 'take the pot'. The exact amount that members pay in during each savings 'round' varies from group to group, and can be anything from Ug Sh 5000 to Ug Sh 1 million (\$1.50 up to \$330) depending on the wealth of the individuals involved, and so too the frequency of the rounds/payouts differs – though in practice, most groups try to meet at least once per month. In addition, both the size of the payouts and the mechanism used to determine in which sequence

members receive these also vary between groups. Thus, although at least some groups do pay out the total 'pot' during each round, it is in fact much more common for such clubs to pay out only about 75–80% of the total money they receive – something which then allows them to build up additional financial reserves as well. These reserves can then also be lent out to members as loans, on which interest of up to 10% is charged. Some groups determine the order in which their members receive payouts on a strictly rotational basis, whilst others follow a needs-based model (i.e. they decide which of their members is in the greatest need at that particular time), whilst others again use a lottery system. In all instances, these schemes enforce strict discipline, whereby failure to observe group etiquette, or to keep up with the regular payments (without good reason), is invariably met with severe penalties. In Bugamba, as across East Africa, these clubs spend much of their time handing out, and enforcing, sizeable fines to their members, for transgressions ranging from everything from being late to a meeting, to not concentrating when decisions are being made, to not paying contributions on time.²⁵

The number of savings clubs operating in Bugamba sub-county has risen dramatically, from 4 to 5 groups in the late-1990s to more than 40 today. In most cases, the new groups have between 15 and 20 members, although one has as few as 6 people, another more than 30. Why, when faced with educational and other financial costs, have so many people in Bugamba turned to these savings schemes and clubs rather than bank loans? Part of the answer lies in the history of mutual support societies in Uganda and the region more broadly. With limited formal banking facilities, informal organizations of this sort have long been the most appropriate response to *any* kind of major social challenge (of which rising school fees is but the latest one).

The earliest mutual societies were probably collective agricultural work parties (for sharing labour or produce during harvest or times of need), which have been prevalent throughout the western Great Lakes region at least since 'finger millet' (eleusine, in Runyankore/Rukiga: *oburo*) was introduced here, around 500 AD.²⁶ During the colonial era local administrations also ran a system of communal work parties, to which all households were expected to contribute one man per session, for purposes of assisting with road-building, bridge construction, forest planting and other public works projects. In many cases, the individuals who met for their work parties formed lasting collectivities, at least some of which later mobilized for political purposes. For example, during the 1950s, the leadership of the Kumanyana Movement – a nascent ethno-nationalist movement representing the region's Bairu people – used these groups to help recruit among rural population. Kumanyana – the word means literally 'to get to know each other' – in many ways modelled itself as a collective work party 'writ large'.²⁷ However, it was during the post-colonial years of political unrest that mutual support societies played their most important role. In particular, in the context of collapsing state services, people increasingly turned to burial societies (*bataka twezike*) as a means for meeting the cost of funerals. Later, and especially into the era of the HIV/AIDS epidemic, many of these groups took on additional functions as well: assisting with palliative care, organizing the return of dead bodies (in relation to those individuals who had died in, for example, a hospital in town), putting death notices (*ebirango*) out on the radio and so on.

The growth of *savings and credit* associations has been fostered by development discourse and has paralleled Uganda's post-1986 educational reforms. Indeed, rising school fees and the growth of these savings clubs could be interpreted as linked examples of 'neoliberal' reform. During the 1990s, international development agencies saw RoSCAs as a means for delivering informal banking services to rural Uganda. Although in the Southwest some elite men had been taking part in *ebigombe* from at least the

mid-1980s, after about 1992, the practice became much more widespread. Donors promoted access to credit, and the Ugandan Government's Microfinance Act of 2003 required larger savings clubs to register and open savings accounts.²⁸ Many groups were reluctant to formalize their status, but at least one of Bugamba's burial societies has subsequently transformed into a broader catering business, benefiting from commercial bank loans.

The rules of a rotating credit association provides certain advantages for an individual hoping to use his/her participation in the group as a means for meeting a rising household financial burden, such as those associated with school fees. On the one hand, money which is put into a RoSCA cannot be accessed by the giver, other than through one of the group's rotational payouts or a group-sanctioned loan. The temptation to spend the money on anything other than the specific object being saved for is removed. Involvement in a savings club enforces savings discipline, particularly important in the context of rising school fees, where large lump-sum payments become due once each term.

Money put into a savings club is also placed beyond the reach of any relative or friend who might otherwise lay claim to it. Participation in an *ekigombe* effectively 'protects' an individual's wealth from multiple other demands. In theory, another family member could ask an *ekigombe* member to take out a loan on their behalf. However, this tends not to happen, given that the *ekigombe* charges interest on such loans and the family member would be generating an additional debt for their relative. As Shipton notes with regard to Luo contribution clubs in Western Kenya, 'it allows one to save without breaking Rule One of social life ... never look selfish'.²⁹ In this way, RoSCAs might even be said to constitute a distinct 'sphere of exchange' of their own.³⁰ They have the further benefit of keeping secret one's total financial worth. In Bugamba, and probably elsewhere, the actual *practice* of participating in an *ekigombe* also engenders an intense form of sociality. Accompanying the self-discipline and peer expectations are also feelings of 'communitas' and solidarity in the face of rising anxiety over school fees.

It is common practice for each *ekigombe* to hold its regular meetings at the home of one of its members, also in rotation, and for each of these occasions to also involve – in addition to all business relating to the group's finances – much talk of people's difficulties, and other forms of socializing, and oftentimes also much revelry as well. For each of these meetings, the host alone is expected to provide all of the food, which *must* include at least some meat (the word *ekigombe* in fact refers to the sharing of meat) and usually also plenty of alcohol (either locally produced banana wine or commercially bottled beer, depending on the wealth of the group involved). The host might even be expected to provide entertainment (for example, by hiring the service of one of the various mobile disco outfits that operate throughout Bugamba), and – in the event that the festivities run on into the night – to provide lodgings for his/her fellow *ekigombe* members as well. In at least some groups, the host also hires a commercial photographer for the occasion (and later distributes all of the photographs to those who had attended), whilst in others, he/she also provides guests with a 'take-home' gift at the end.³¹ In one case, the host gave each of her fellow *ekigombe* members a mosquito net at the end of their meeting, from a batch of nets that she had recently been given by a non-government organisation with which she is associated.

Education and the remaking of reciprocity

Whatever the exact reasons for people's increased participation in rotating savings clubs, the proliferation of these groups has produced a wide range of social effects, reordering

pre-existing reciprocities and interdependencies. Exchange relations are constantly subject to ongoing change, but the shifts caused by the proliferation of *ebigombe* have been particularly marked. Graeber has argued that this marks a general move from what he defines as ‘hierarchical’ types of exchange relations, towards what he calls ‘reciprocal’ ones.³²

According to Graeber, hierarchical relations are those which characteristically ‘do not tend to operate in terms of reciprocity but rather by a logic of precedent. If one gives money to a beggar (or a charity fund), they will almost certainly *not* feel obliged to return something of equal value; rather, they will be likely to ask for more’. He goes on to note that ‘there are endless variations here too – from institutionalized plunder or ritualized theft to redistribution, inheritance or other gifts that pass the superior status to former inferiors – but, except for the last, they all presume a permanent or at least ongoing relation that has nothing to do with reciprocal exchange because it is assumed to have nothing to do with equality’. Against this, reciprocal relations are those characterized by: an ‘exchange of compliments, or favors [*sic*], or rounds of drinks. Such relationships can be broken off after every round because the return is considered to be a more or less exact equivalent of the initial gift ... Reciprocity of this sort is about maintaining one’s personal autonomy in a relatively equal relationship’.³³

Graeber’s dichotomy may be simplistic, but it captures something of the shift that has occurred in exchange relations in Bugamba. Before Museveni’s educational reforms, practically the *only* way in which anyone could attend school (outside of a narrow group of elite households), was through having their fees paid by a wealthy patron. Access to education conformed to a much longer history of patron–client relations in this part of the world (communal work parties and forms of clientage have been prevalent throughout the Great Lakes for centuries).³⁴ From the time the first missionary schools opened in the Southwest, in the 1910s, it became standard practice for either missionaries themselves, or else chiefs and other office holders, or even schoolteachers, to identify those children who had the greatest chance of educational success, and to then support those students through their school careers.

At first, this support frequently required the child involved to move into a patron’s home. As more schools opened across rural areas (a process which sped up following the publication of the Castle Commission’s Report in 1963) – such assistance tended to instead involve only the payment of fees. For example, one of the first individuals to be educated in Bugamba was Mzee Atugonza (a pseudonym), who attended what became Mbarara High School in the early 1940s (throughout this article, we use pseudonyms for all of our respondents). Having been identified as academically capable at a young age, he moved to the household of a local county (*saza*) chief, and part of his upbringing was also in the court of the King (*mugabe*) of Ankole. By the time Bugamba’s first university graduate, Komugisha Michael, attended secondary school, in the 1970s, his patron – another local political leader – provided only the fees. Nevertheless, the basic structure of patron–client relations continued to hold, and it remained important even into the period of the NRM’s reforms. We know of at least one case in which a local ‘big man’ extended his patronage network throughout the 2000s, using UPE money. This individual embezzled UPE funds from a bank account holding UPE funds through a post he held in the district administration in Mbarara. He used these to pay school fees for children based throughout the district. In all these examples – both historical and contemporary – offering support with school fees engenders what Graeber calls ‘hierarchical relations’ of exchange. There is no expectation for the recipient to in any sense ‘reciprocate’ the patron’s gift. On the contrary, the general assumption here is that once a patron has begun

to pay a child's school fees, he/she will continue to do so for the remainder of that student's career, in return only for that child's – or his/her household's – ongoing loyalty and support. In keeping with the longer history of patronage relations in the Great Lakes region, such loyalty is usually talked about in terms of trust, *okwesiga*, or love, *okukunda*, and may be demonstrated in any number of ways, from providing labour for a family function, to lending assistance with a political campaign, to contributing defence in a time of trouble.

Against these hierarchical patronage relations, savings clubs conform more to Graeber's alternative category of 'reciprocal relations' of exchange. RoSCAs *do* require a more balanced reciprocity, with loans and financial 'gifts' having to be returned in equal measure (and, moreover, in a regular and predictable order – a point to which we will return), and they *are* therefore, structurally at least, predicated upon relations between equals. In most cases, this means that groups bring together members of similar socio-economic status. As a result, awareness of wealth divisions within the locality as a whole has become much more acute. Nevertheless, the requirement to constantly reciprocate represents a significant challenge to some individuals, especially those who may have formerly called upon patronage relations. Whilst RoSCAs enforce strict discipline, pre-existing patron–client ties may continue to be called upon by individuals facing situations of difficulty, as the case of Kayongo Fred shows.

Case study: Kayongo Fred (Part 1)

Consider, for example, the case of one individual, Kayongo Fred, who as of 2008, was a long-standing client of at least two 'big men' in Bugamba, and who also worked as a casual wage labourer in the household of another prominent household (from which he derives around Ug Sh 5000 a week – approximately \$1.30 – his only regular income). In late 2008, Kayongo joined an *ekigombe* with 25 members, each of whom paid in Ug Sh 5000 per fortnight, giving a regular 'pot' of Ug Sh 100,000 (in this instance, the group paid out 80% of its total takings). In early 2009, on the fifth round of the *ekigombe's* total cycle, Kayongo received the pot and used the money to pay one of his son's school fees (which were Ug Sh 90,000 for that term). However, two rounds further on, Kayongo was falling behind with the fortnightly repayments, and fears were raised that he might have to drop out completely. In response, the group began to fine him and eventually sent a 'delegation' to his home to discuss the situation. However, even this had little effect. In the end, then, Kayongo was forced to turn to his pre-existing patrons and to ask them to bail him out. Finally – and although one of the patrons was initially reluctantly to assist – Kayongo was provided with the money to get him through four additional rounds, and with this support, he eventually managed to complete the whole *ekigombe* cycle.

As noted by Graeber, the reciprocity of *ebigombe* does also allow their members to drop out at the end of each cycle. Indeed, our ethnographic analysis reveals that this practice is in fact remarkably common, suggesting that most *ebigombe* do *not*, therefore, tend to produce enduring relations of exchange, whilst they can engender a limited form of what Graeber calls 'personal autonomy'.³⁵ Following the completion of a saving cycle (determined by the number of participants), each of its members may look to move on to another group, selecting their alternative based on any number of factors, from where the other group meets, to who else is in it, to how good its parties are. Once a decision has been made, the person involved might then typically approach the new group's 'book keeper' to ask to join, following which the group itself will invariably carry out 'due

diligence' to of its own, in attempt to ascertain the recruit's potential reliability. Usually this is straightforward, but less so in the case of someone who is new to the locality: '*mufuruka*' (lit: 'a person who has relocated').

Case study: Kayongo Fred (Part 2)

Following Kayongo's completion of the cycle, he dropped out of that RoSCA (which he had joined through his wife's friend) and sought to join another. The first group he approached refused him to join, given his earlier financial problems. The second group he approached was aware of Kayongo's previous difficulties, but eventually allowed him to join – albeit after much deliberation – on the basis that his brother, Balamu, was already a member of the group. The thinking here seems to have been that because Balamu owned a number of goats, he would be able to cover Kayongo's payments, in the event that the latter got into difficulties. The extent to which Balamu himself consented to this is not clear. In the months following, Kayongo did indeed get into trouble again, and this placed a great strain on the brothers' relationship.

The agencies and donors that have sponsored the growth of savings associations, and other forms of microfinance, in Uganda over the past 20 years or so would doubtless regard much of this as a success story. Even Kayongo's case could be interpreted as an example of 'empowerment': an individual who was previously beholden to his patron becoming – albeit through ongoing interventions – an equal, and somewhat autonomous exchange partner in his own right. Yet one could also argue that his social status and family relationships have become rather more precarious as a result, and that ultimately Kayongo became more dependent on his kin. The promise of 'autonomous individualism' may produce its opposite. It can also lead to other less desirable effects. It has also led to an increase in cases of people attempting to 'game' their positions across different savings clubs. Although *ebigombe*, like many RoSCAs, are reasonably effective at maintaining discipline *within* the group, and all groups check the background of anyone wishing to join, this does not stop at least some people 'playing off' one group against another. This appears to be particularly marked amongst those people who, for one reason or another, lead mobile lives and are willing to shun the reciprocity expected of members. The most startling economic success stories in relation to the new political economy of *ebigombe* relate to people who have effectively 'gamed' *between* savings associations in this way.

Case study: Dunstan Naheeza

Dunstan Naheeza, on account of his official position within the county administration, had multiple ties across a number of different localities. In 2009, he used his connections in one locality to join an *ekigombe* based there. Three months later – on the fourth round of the *ekigombe*'s cycle – he received the pot, of around Ug Sh 500,000 (approximately \$170). In the following few weeks, he used this money to join at least five other RoSCAs, based all over the county. In all cases, the groups involved agreed to his joining, presumably on the basis of his general good standing. In short order he took the pot from each of these other groups as well. By this means, within just a few months of joining the first group, Dunstan had raised nearly Ug Sh 4 million (about \$1300), which he used to both pay a range of school fees commitments – for both his own and his brother's children – and to partly fund a new hotel business in a nearby town. Following this he was left with a significant financial commitment to all of the RoSCAs he had joined

(which totalled around Ug Sh 200,000 per month, for several years), but his combined income from his waged employment and the new hotel venture more than covered this. In addition, his membership of the various *ebigombe* further cemented his ties in each of the localities in which they operated – something which Dunstan himself regarded as particularly important for his future political ambitions. He has gone on to develop a further set of businesses.

Dunstan's case is somewhat unusual, in that attempts to develop multiple positions across numerous rotating savings clubs are more often a sign of overreach, borne of desperation. For example, we came across another case, not dissimilar to that of Kayongo's, in which the individual involved was struggling to keep up the repayments to his *ekigombe* in Bugamba, and so decided to join another group, in his wife's natal village, as a means for raising the necessary funds. In this instance, the move resulted only in his debts, and associated difficulties, multiplying, and he was eventually forced to run away from Bugamba. Another individual, whose situation was even more precarious, joked that a number of *ebigombe* were even out to 'kill him' on account of the debts he had run up. As an occasional wage labourer in Mbarara town, with two wives from different parts, he too had been able to develop multiple positions across savings clubs based in several different localities. Unlike Dunstan, he had been unable to keep up the repayments.

RoSCAs facilitate both a level of individual agency and a strong sense of a social collective. At the same time as these associations allow some social autonomy, they play an important role in creating new social identities and senses of personhood. The peer-pressure placed by RoSCAs on their members may not even be experienced or articulated as a 'constraint'.

Savings clubs and 'time discipline'

Our ethnographic research has shown that people in Bugamba turn to rotating savings clubs for a variety of reasons. *Ebigombe* help to enforce savings discipline, assist in the 'protection' of one's wealth (from the range of additional demands that may be placed on it) and offer a social catharsis from financial pressures, engendering a sense of shared purpose and intimacy amongst those involved. A key paradox remains. These groups are poorly suited for meeting school fees, partly because, ideally, everyone would need to make a withdrawal at the same time. As a result, these societies are never able to meet all of their members' savings needs, or at least, not in the way that people might anticipate them doing so. If *ebigombe* do indeed constitute a distinct 'sphere of exchange', this does not, in itself, guarantee reciprocal relations, as Graeber suggests. It may instead *increase* individuals' social dependency, and nurture long-term anxieties around school fees.

Key to understanding this problem is to recognize that the educational calendar recalibrates pre-existing temporal understandings. Historically, everyday idioms of time in Bugamba – a predominantly subsistence-agricultural economy – focused primarily on the broad daily concepts of 'morning' (*akasheeshe*), 'afternoon' (*omwabazyo*) and 'night' (*ekiro*), and/or the seasonal categories of 'long-dry season' (*ekyanda*), 'short-rainy season' (*katumba*), 'short-dry season' (*akanda*), 'long-rainy season' (*eitumba*). It tended to be only in the context of attending 'special events' – church ceremonies, political functions, wedding parties and the like – that people ever used more precise temporal categories, such as those of 'clock time' (e.g. '10 am', *eshaaha inna*).³⁶ People's engagement with saving clubs has created another set of temporal categories, namely

those of the '*ekigombe* meeting-round'. In keeping with the fact that most clubs meet once per month, the interval is usually referred to by the word for month, *okwezi*.³⁷ These categories have engendered another form of time discipline, given that *ekigombe* members have to pay into the club, and may also receive money from it.

Formal schooling has increased awareness of education-related temporal categories, including those of the 'school day', which runs from 8:00 am (*eshaaha ibiri*) to 3:00 pm (*eshaaha mwenda*), five days per week (from Monday to Friday), and the three annual school terms (which begin around February, June and October, respectively). Because these education-related timescales are enforced in new kinds of ways, they could also be said to have engendered a new form of 'time discipline', of the kind that E.P. Thompson identified as having emerged from the Industrial Revolution in eighteenth-century Europe.³⁸

The time disciplines required by school timetables and those of the *ebigombe* are fundamentally incompatible. The school one requires people to pay their fees three times per year, at the start of each term, whilst the latter guarantees that these same individuals will receive their club's 'pot' only once per saving cycle. For a group with an average of 18 members, which meets once per month, this takes a year and a half to complete. Recognizing this contradiction, then, in recent years practically every *ekigombe* in Bugamba has begun to develop a range of new practices aimed at overcoming the problem. In this regard, one of the simplest solutions is for a group to simply 'speed up' the frequency of its meeting-rounds around the start of academic terms. Thus, although most *ebigombe* members continue to refer to their club's rounds as *okwezi* ('a month'), in practice, it is not uncommon for a given group's *kwezi* to take place as frequently as once per week around the start of a school term, and then at only two- or three-month long intervals during other times of the year. In addition, savings clubs may attempt to overcome this contradiction by 'stockpiling' their loan reserves, for release around the start of school terms. For example, we know of at least one group in Bugamba that will make loans to its members *only* in February, June and October. It is also common for schools to agree individual repayment timetables to help those families who need to stagger their payments. At least one *ekigombe* in Bugamba has petitioned a local primary school to allow its members special arrangements on the timing of their school fees payments.

Each of these practices represents only a partial solution, and each generates additional problems of its own. For example, increasing the frequency of meeting-rounds around the start of the school terms only intensifies the pressure for members to raise their requisite contributions; using loans to meet members' school fees commitments increases the financial burden of those fees (given that loans do generate interest) and so on. All of these meetings and negotiations take a great deal of time and energy. In the context of rising school costs, people may turn to RoSCAs as a source of support, but these associations are expressions of sociality more generally and are not reducible to individual financial strategy. As a result, as Shipton notes, 'rotating contribution clubs are no panacea for solving African poverty'.³⁹ Instead their value is in their flexibility, and in the way that responsibilities to one's peers can be used to invoke certain social relationships and distance oneself from others.

The forms of moral autonomy generated within these savings clubs could be seen to echo the ethical and moral agency at the heart of Sen's model of capabilities and social justice. However, the connections between social morality and autonomous personhood are not straightforward. Drawing on recent debates about welfare politics in the Southern African context, Ferguson makes a strong and provocative case for the moral value of

social dependency, especially in the context of an economy which no longer relies on productive labour and is thus able to cast out the unemployed as worthless and 'asocial'. In contrast to Graeber's attention to the 'reciprocal relations' generated by economic exchange, Ferguson attends to 'care, moral connection and responsible obligation'.⁴⁰

As he notes 'social policy ... should not treat 'dependency' as a disease – the task is not to eliminate dependence but to construct desirable forms of it'. Like Sen, both Graeber and Ferguson are exploring questions of human moral capability, if in a rather more anthropological vein. This allows them to highlight the different connections between morality, dependency and reciprocity that can exist within African societies. If savings clubs are not in themselves Africa's economic 'panacea', nor should they be invoked for their moral idealism.

Conclusion

This article has explored some of the effects of Uganda's 15-year educational experiment. We have argued that national initiatives to expand educational provision in the face of high levels of population growth have been accompanied by a range of social dynamics and attitudinal changes. By situating these educational trends within a grounded account of rural social and economic relations in one part of rural Uganda, this paper shows how the opportunities opened up by more schooling have occurred in parallel with a growing reliance on loans and rotating contribution clubs (*ebigombe*) within one rural community, reshaping notions of reciprocity, patronage and sociality. But we have sought to go well beyond the economic arguments. Beyond providing access to finances, *ebigombe* schemes create new problems and contradictions. They open up new forms of personhood and rework (and even challenge) older idioms of sociality. The provision of credit through rotating savings clubs offers individuals the potential to develop their own financial strategy and to facilitate entrepreneurialism. However, these clubs can also reinforce existing patronage relations and dependencies for those unable to handle the financial discipline that accompanies these reciprocal exchanges.

Ebigombe relationships are about much more than addressing education, and we have argued that they only provide a partial solution to the cyclical pressure of meeting school fees that many households face. There are other paradoxes. UPE and USE policies have reinforced social expectation on families to invest, emotionally and economically, in their children's education. The poor quality of UPE provision has in turn created new forms of educational inequality.

What are the implications of this study for broader international debates around education for the poorest within development policy? Sen's emphasis on developing human capabilities is at once a moral vision and a way of foregrounding individual agency and freedom. However the value placed by people in Bugamba on these new *ebigombe* cannot be read simply as an appetite for moral and financial autonomy. These educational and social changes do not necessitate a shift to autonomous individualism, but instead allow opportunities to craft moral personhood through the negotiation of both reciprocity and social dependency.

The growth in savings clubs and informal credit associations in Uganda is part of a broader reworking of social relations around educational values and aspirations. 'Empowerment' is too simplistic a frame for capturing the complexity of these transformations. Opening up access to schooling in Uganda and elsewhere in East Africa may not only create new policy dilemmas of equity and quality, but it also facilitates new forms of moral personhood and new genres of associational life.

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Notes

1. Kajubi, "Educational Reform," 323; Heyneman 'Education during a period of austerity'.
2. UPE became the second Millennium Development Goal in September 2000.
3. Cheney, *Pillars of the Nation*.
4. Bategeka and Okurut, Overseas Development Institute, *Policy Brief*.
5. Uganda Bureau of Statistics, *Uganda National Household Survey*, 2012.
6. UWEZO, *Are Our Children*.
7. Omollo et al., "Enrolment in USE Schools."
8. Sen, *Development as Freedom*, One study which has examined the wider social effects of Uganda's UPE experiment is Meinhart, *Hopes in Friction*.
9. Uganda Bureau of Statistics. *Uganda National Census*, 2012.
10. See Grogan, "Universal Primary Education"; Nishimura et al., "Impacts of the Universal."
11. Nishimura et al., "Impacts of the Universal," 164–166; Cheney, *Pillars of the Nation* and Hedger et al., *Sector Budget Support*. See also Penny et al., *Education sector reform*.
12. Kavuma, "Free Universal."
13. Omollo et al., "Enrolment in USE Schools."
14. Ssenkibirwa, "Report Pins Schools."
15. Wane and Martin, *Education and Health Services*.
16. Uganda Bureau of Statistics, *UNHS*.
17. Madhavan-Nambiar et al., *Analysis of Various Household*.
18. Fine and Rose, "Education and the Post-Washington Consensus."
19. Dreze and Sen, *An Uncertain Glory*.
20. Kafeero, "Teachers Strike."
21. Mehrotra and Delamonica, "Household Costs," 51.
22. New Vision, June 6, 2013. See <http://www.newvision.co.ug/news/643671-students-loan-scheme-starts-next-month.html> [Accessed December 17, 2013].
23. Okurut et al., *Microfinance and Poverty Reduction*.
24. Ardener and Burman, *Money-Go Round*.
25. Gugerty, "You Can't Save Alone."
26. Schoenbrun, *A Green Place*, 6–9, 72–73.
27. Doornbos, *Not All the King's Men*, 117–131.
28. Okurut et al., *Microfinance and Poverty Reduction*, 6–10.
29. Shipton, *Credit between Cultures*, 174.
30. Bohannan, "Some Principles."
31. Vokes, "On 'The Ultimate Patronage Machine.'"
32. Graeber, *Debt*, 8.
33. *Ibid.*, 9.
34. The earliest type of patron–client relationship, *kugabira*, involved a form of cattle exchange and probably developed around 1300–1400 AD (Schoenbrun, *A Green Place*, 223–224).
35. Graeber, "Debt, Violence, and Impersonal Markets."
36. Lit: 'the fourth hour'. In Runyankore/Rukiga, 'clock time' begins at 6 am (i.e. at dawn).
37. *Okwezi* means both 'month' and 'moon'.
38. Thompson, "Work-discipline."
39. Shipton, *Credit between Cultures*, 120.
40. Ferguson, "Declarations of Dependence"; Graeber, "Debt, Violence, and Impersonal Markets" and Sen, 2009; See also Krige "Letting money work for us".

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